RIOT LESSON 4: THE AMAZING BRAIN

LEARNING INTENTIONS	SUCCESS CRITERIA
Students will: • Learn that different areas of the brain have different functions. • Understand that the adolescent brain is still developing. • Learn the difference between a reaction and a response.	**Students will be able to:** • Name the three main sections of the brain that contribute to anxiety. • Be able to name and practise at least two calming strategies.

EXERCISE 1 THREE PARTS OF THE BRAIN

Match each part of the brain to what it does. Write the letter next to each one.

Brain stem	
Amygdala (limbic system)	
Prefrontal cortex	

A. Keeps us alive and reacts to danger

B. The alarm system that triggers fight, flight or freeze

C. The smart part that stops, thinks and chooses

EXERCISE 2 FIGHT, FLIGHT OR FREEZE

What can happen to our body during the fight, flight or freeze response?

Think about a time when you were in 'fight, flight or freeze' mode. What did you do? How did you return to calm? (You don't have to share this.)

EXERCISE 3 PRACTISE GUIDED MINDFULNESS

It is important to practise these skills when we are not in a crisis moment so that when something happens and our amygdala is firing, we can easily draw on them. Try three rounds of box breathing.

Box breathing: breathe in for 4, hold for 4, breathe out for 4, hold for 4.

EXERCISE 4 PLAN IN MY POCKET

Some things that make me feel anxious are...

When I feel anxious, I feel this in my body...

When I feel anxious, I have these thoughts...

When I feel anxious, I do these things...

EXERCISE 5 PLAN IN MY POCKET: MY SKILLS

Choose the skills you'll use when you feel anxious.

- ☐ Take 3 deep breaths
- ☐ Practise mindfulness
- ☐ Tense and relax your muscles
- ☐ Count from 1 to 100
- ☐ Find a trusted person to talk to
- ☐ Listen to music
- ☐ Take a break in your safe place
- ☐ Exercise, run or jog
- ☐ Stretching
- ☐ Use encouraging self-talk
- ☐ Think of 3 things you are grateful for
- ☐ Challenge unhelpful thoughts
- ☐ Other: _____